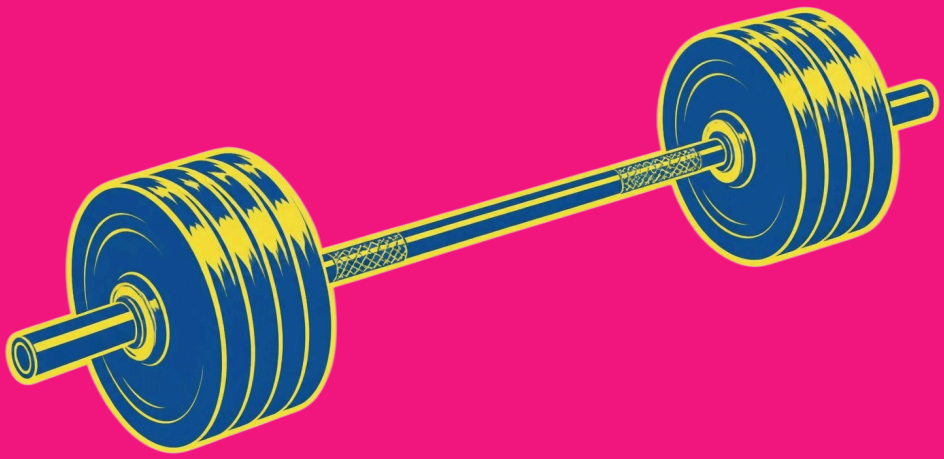
THE BARBELL BEATS THE MIDDLE

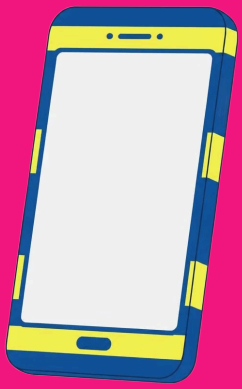


BY DAMON NELSON

THE NUMBERS BEHIND THE SHIFT

200B

DAILY VIEWS ON SHORTS



YOUTUBE CEO NEAL MOHAN
JAN 21, 2026 LETTER

THE NEW TV

"#1 in streaming watchtime in the U.S. for nearly three years, according to Nielsen"

NEAL MOHAN

"YOUTUBE IS THE NEW TV BECAUSE CREATORS ARE THE NEW PRIME TIME."

NEAL MOHAN

THREE JOBS, THREE FORMATS



“Use Shorts for discovery.
Use long form for depth.
Use creators for trust.”

SEARCH ENGINE JOURNAL
GREG JARBOE · FEB 2, 2026

DAMON'S OPINION, NOT YOUTUBE'S

THE BARBELL



GO SHORT TO GET FOUND.
GO LONG TO EARN TRUST.

SHORT GETS YOU FOUND



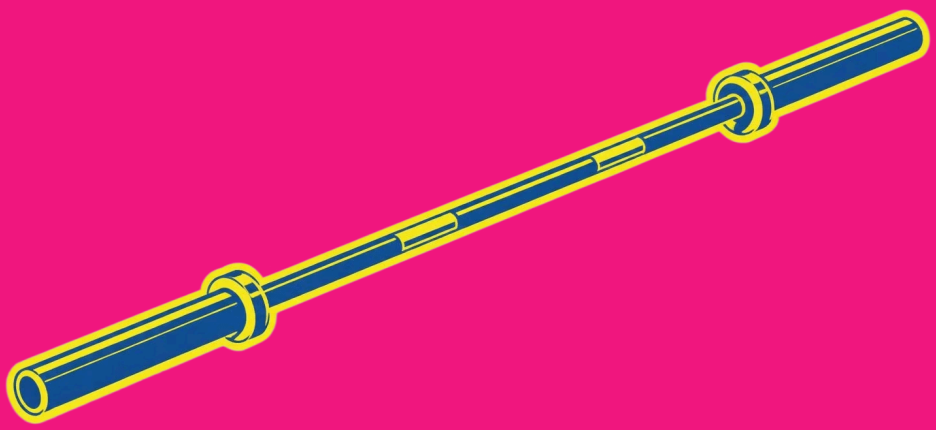
SHORT IS HOW STRANGERS DISCOVER YOU.

LONG EARNS THE TRUST



DEPTH TURNS A VIEWER INTO A BUYER.

THE LUKEWARM MIDDLE



Half teaching, half pitching.

TOO LONG TO SKIM.
TOO SHORT TO TRUST.

YOUR EMAILS ARE A BARBELL TOO



ONE QUICK IDEA OR THE WHOLE STORY.

Match the subject line to the end you're on.

Don't promise depth and deliver a skim, or promise fast and deliver a wall of text.

RECAP

LOAD BOTH ENDS

SHORT TO GET FOUND

LONG TO EARN TRUST

SKIP THE LUKEWARM MIDDLE

Match the subject line to the end you're on.

YOUR MOVE: PICK AN END AND LIFT.

Join the Pit Crew, one email a week at **DamonNelson.com.**